

The Discourse on the Eighth and Ninth

Codex Reference: VI,6

Translated by: James Brashler, Peter A. Dirkse, and Douglas M. Parrott

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Editor's Introduction

(VI, 6)

Introduced by Douglas M. Parrott

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Although its title is lost, this tractate has been identified as Hermetic from the use of the names Trismegistus and Hermes and close similarities with previously known Hermetic tractates. It has been named from its contents, using a phrase found in the tractate itself (53,24-26). It describes in dialogue form the process by which a spiritual guide (mystagogue) leads an initiate to a mystical experience.

The eighth and the ninth indicate the eighth and ninth spheres surrounding the earth. In ancient times it was thought that the first seven spheres were the realms of the sun, moon, and planets, the lower powers whose control over human life was not necessarily benevolent. The eighth and ninth spheres thus designate the beginning of the divine realm, the levels beyond the control of the lower powers. At death the soul would journey through the seven spheres, and after successful passage it would reach the eighth and the ninth, the levels at which the soul could experience true bliss. Furthermore, the eighth and the ninth spheres can also indicate advanced stages of spiritual development. The tractate possibly assumes yet another sphere, a higher, tenth sphere, where God himself dwells, though this is not entirely clear.

The tractate begins with an introductory discussion (52,2-53,21) in which the initiate secures the approval of the mystagogue to request the experience of the eighth and the ninth. He then makes the formal request (53,24-27). The process leading to the experience begins with a period of instruction, which culminates in a carefully constructed prayer, perhaps spoken by both participants (53,28-57,25). At the heart of the prayer is a request for the visionary experience (57,3-9). Following an embrace between initiate and mystagogue, the mystagogue has his vision (57,28-58,22). Then, directed by the mystagogue, the initiate enters first the eighth, and then the ninth (58,22-60,1).

Following that, the mystagogue exhorts the initiate to silence and gives instruction about continuing in the way of the mystical experience (60,1-10). The tractate concludes with a hymn of thanks by the initiate, and instructions for writing and preserving the account of the experience (60,10-63,32).

Assumed in the tractate are earlier levels of spiritual attainment. They are not described in Disc. 8-9 but it is clear that two things need to have occurred in order to be ready for the experience of the eighth and ninth: the attainment of purity of life according to the standard of divine law (56,27-57,1) and the banishing of ignorance by mastering the knowledge found in certain books (54,6-18).

The attainment of the final two stages for the initiate requires that the mystagogue have the experience first and thereby become the embodiment of universal mind, which is the ninth (58,1-22). The initiate then enters the eighth by recognizing the presence of universal mind, and responds to this recognition by joining the chorus of the eighth and singing a silent hymn to universal mind. He reaches the ninth when he experiences his own unity with universal mind and receives the confirmatory vision in which the chorus of the eighth sings to him (59,24-60,1).

This and other Hermetic tractates may well have been used in the context of small groups devoted to secret knowledge and mystical experience, in which those who were more advanced would teach and direct neophytes, and in which certain cultic acts were engaged in (prayers and hymns are found throughout the Hermetic corpus). The tractates would have served as the basis for discussion and as texts for individual meditation.

Evidence that Disc. 8-9 was composed in Egypt is found in references to the city of Diospolis, as well as to hieroglyphic characters and gods with animal faces—all found in the section beginning 61,18. The designation of the mystagogue as Hermes and Trismegistus also suggests Egypt. A second-century C.E. date for the composition is possible, because of affinities with the thought of the Middle Platonist Albinus.